

PUBLIC ENGAGEMENT PLAN

A guide for staff on how to meaningfully engage the public and ensure community input shapes County decisions.

Foreward by the County Executive

Version 1.0



**ALONE,
WE CAN DO SO
LITTLE; TOGETHER,
WE CAN DO SO
MUCH.”**

— Helen Keller

FOREWORD FROM

THE COUNTY EXECUTIVE

Marin County serves one of the most engaged and informed communities in California. Our residents show up and care deeply about their neighborhoods, their families, and the decisions that shape their daily lives. A 2025 voter survey confirmed it: Marin residents want timely information and a real say in the decisions that shape their lives.

Across the county, historically underserved communities have shown up and walked away with nothing to show for it. That erodes trust, and trust, once broken, is hard to earn back.

The Public Engagement Plan (or PEP) is our commitment to being clear with community members about how they can participate, what level of influence they have, and how their input will be used. We commit to engaging early, following through when we say we will, and doing the harder, slower work of building genuine relationships with the communities who have the most at stake and the least reason to trust us. That means honest communication about what's open to input and what isn't, processes designed to reduce barriers rather than create them, and reporting back after every engagement effort so people know what happened with what they shared and how their input was considered in the final decision.

Every staff member, vendor, or consultant who touches a project, program, or policy that affects the public is expected to use this Plan. Its tools, definitions, and step-by-step guidance ensure consistent public engagement across every department.

We'll keep refining this document as we learn, but the values it's built on aren't changing: Excellence, Equity, Respect, Collaboration, Integrity, and Innovation. Those are the standards we hold ourselves to every time we sit across from a community member and ask for their time and their trust.

Derek Johnson
County Executive
Marin County

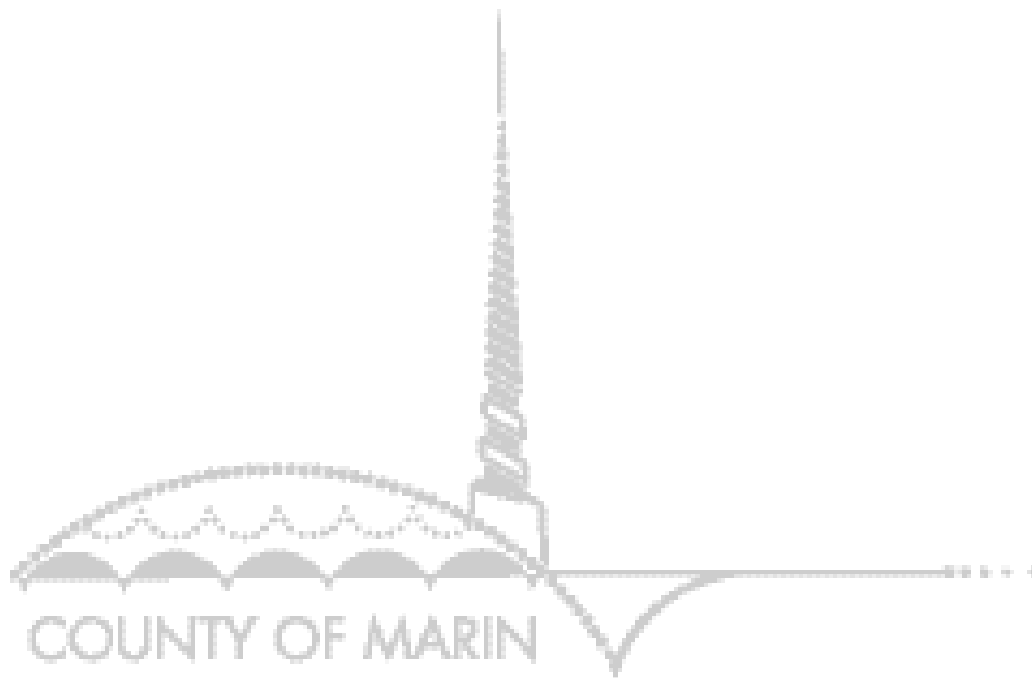


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HOW TO USE THIS PLAN

This Plan is both policy and a practical reference. Following its steps is an expectation for every county staff member who touches public-facing work. It's also designed to be used as a day-to-day guide — you don't need to read it cover to cover to put it to work.

Consider your current experience level

1

If you are new to engagement work, begin with page 8. It walks through the essentials in order and was written with first-timers in mind.

2

If you are experienced but working to align, use this to calibrate your current practice against the new countywide standard. Some things will feel familiar; others will prompt recalibration.

3

If you are a seasoned practitioner or direct service provider, use this Plan to connect your work to a shared countywide framework and common language.

Next, let's ensure you can quickly access what you need

Do I even need engagement?	Page 8
What level is right for my project?	Page 10
What do I do next?	Page 16
What documents do I need?	Page 20
I need to go deeper on special engagement-related topics	Page 21
I need a template or reference	Page 30



Remember you have support throughout this process.

Watch for these two callouts throughout

REQUIRED

Non-negotiable. Board-adopted expectations every staff member must meet.

BEST PRACTICE

Professional judgment applies, but don't skip it lightly.

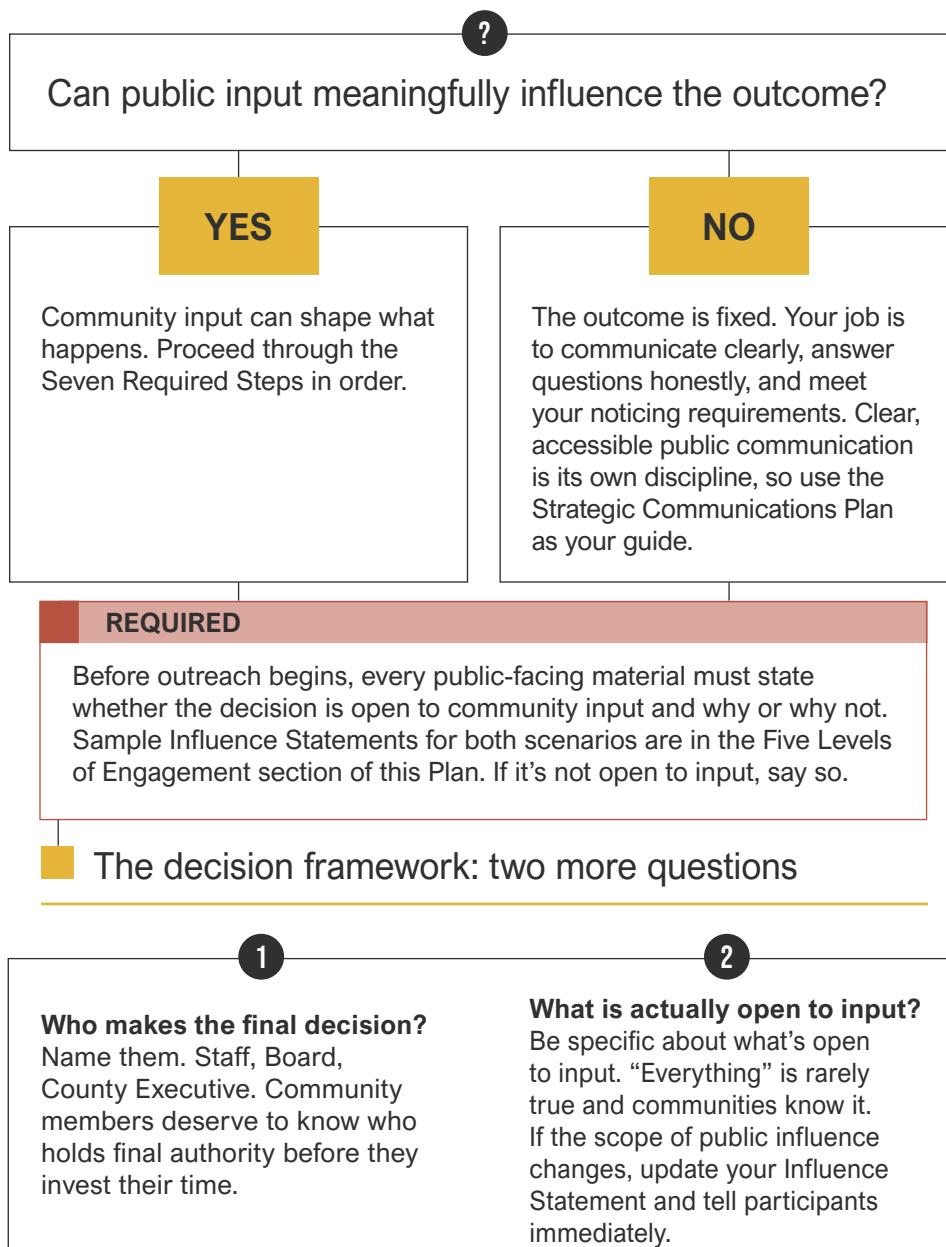
If your project is already underway, start where you are. Publish an Influence Statement, document input, and close the loop when engagement concludes. OCE Communications and the Office of Equity are your partners, reach out before you begin.

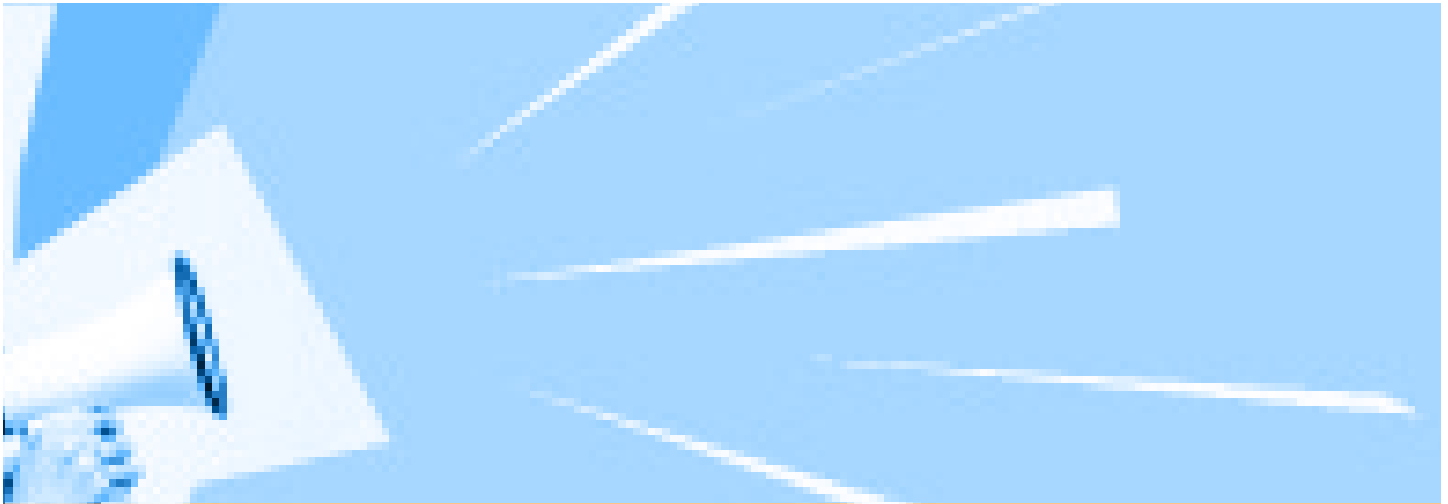
PART ONE: **THE**
ESSENTIALS



ENGAGEMENT OR COMMUNICATION?

Before anything else, one question determines everything that follows.





■ Pre-engagement vs. formal engagement

	Pre-Engagement	Formal Engagement
Purpose	Learn enough to design a credible, inclusive public process	Collect public input to inform a decision, recommendation, or
What it looks like	Early conversations, listening, relationship-building, internal coordination, and community landscape work	Public-facing meetings, surveys, workshops, interviews, advisory or focus groups, listening sessions, or other input
Who is involved	Internal staff, trusted	Community members,
Triggers 7-step process?	No, not by itself	Yes
Formal public commitments?	No. Staff are learning how to design the process, not asking people to shape the outcome yet.	Yes. Staff are asking for input that may influence the outcome.
Key output	Community landscape, internal alignment, draft Influence Statement, recommended engagement approach	Completed engagement tools, What We Heard Report, decision-maker briefing, and closed loop with participants

REQUIRED

If community members are shaping a decision in any setting, even an informal one, you've entered formal engagement territory. Treat it accordingly.

BEST PRACTICE

Never skip pre-engagement entirely because the conversations you have before going public are what make the formal process credible. If you don't know enough about the community to design a process that reaches them, start there.

THE FIVE LEVELS OF ENGAGEMENT

The five levels define how much influence the public can realistically have. The five levels define how much influence the public can realistically have.

INCREASING IMPACT ON THE DECISION 

	INFORM	CONSULT	INVOLVE	COLLABORATE	EMPOWER
PUBLIC PARTICIPATION GOAL	To provide the public with balanced and objective information to assist them in understanding the problem, alternatives, opportunities and/or solutions.	To obtain public feedback on analysis, alternatives and/or decisions.	To work directly with the public throughout the process to ensure that public concerns and aspirations are consistently understood and considered.	To partner with the public in each aspect of the decision including the development of alternatives and the identification of the preferred solution.	To place final decision making in the hands of the public.
PROMISE TO THE PUBLIC	We will keep you informed.	We will keep you informed, listen to and acknowledge concerns and aspirations, and provide feedback on how public input influenced the decision. We will seek your feedback on drafts and proposals.	We will work with you to ensure that your concerns and aspirations are directly reflected in the alternatives developed and provide feedback on how public input influenced the decision.	We will work together with you to formulate solutions and incorporate your advice and recommendations into the decisions to the maximum extent possible.	We will implement what you decide.

Choosing the right level

1	2	3
Is the decision legally or financially constrained? If so, your ceiling may be lower than you'd like. Be honest about that upfront.	What stage is the project in? The earlier you engage, the more influence the community can genuinely have.	Who's most affected? Particularly communities with the least historical access. The level should reflect the real influence available to them.

What each level means

INFORM

You're sharing something the public needs to know. The decision is made. The outcome isn't changing. Your job is to communicate clearly and honestly.

Your promise to the community:
"We'll keep you informed."

Required at minimum:

- Publish an Influence Statement before anything goes public. Put it in plain language.
- Translate all materials into the primary languages of your community before distribution.
- Run at least three channels simultaneously.
- Put a phone number or email address on every piece of material.
- Close the loop. Once the decision is implemented, tell people what happened, when, and what comes next.

What it looks like:

A county road project launches in three weeks. Staff send bilingual direct mailers to every address in the impact zone, post bilingual signage at the site, publish a dedicated webpage with a timeline and FAQ in English and Spanish, and distribute a press release to local and Spanish-language outlets. Residents know what's happening, when it starts, how long it lasts, and who to call. Nobody was asked for input because there was none to give. That's honest. That's Inform done right.

Biggest mistake: Calling it engagement when it isn't. If the decision is made, say so.



CONSULT

You have a proposal, a draft, or a defined set of options. You're asking for feedback before the decision is finalized. Input can shape aspects of the outcome, but the county makes the final call.

Your promise to the community:
"We'll listen and tell you how your input shaped the decision."

Required at minimum:

- Publish an Influence Statement before outreach launches and keep it visible at every touchpoint throughout, not just at launch.
- Open at least three input channels: a survey, a comment form, and at least one in-person or phone option.
- Translate the survey and all materials into the primary languages of your community before they go out.
- Assign a note-taker to every touchpoint. Document input as it's collected.
- At the midpoint of your input window, check who's responded. If the communities most affected aren't represented, extend outreach before closing input.
- Publish a What We Heard summary through the same channels used for outreach within 30 days of closing engagement.
- Name what changed because of community input and what didn't. Explain why

What it looks like:

A department is drafting eligibility criteria for a community health program. Staff publish a bilingual survey, hold two listening sessions in affected neighborhoods at different times of day, and partner with two CBOs to extend reach. Three hundred responses come in. Staff revise two eligibility criteria based on consistent feedback and publish a bilingual What We Heard summary naming the specific changes and explaining why two other requested changes weren't feasible. Participants hear back within 30 days.

Biggest mistake: Collecting input with no plan to report back. If people don't hear what happened with what they shared, they won't show up next time. And they'll tell others not to bother either.

INVOLVE

Community concerns and priorities actively shape the direction of the work. You're not collecting input at a single moment. You're working with communities throughout the process.

Your promise to the community:

"Your input will directly shape this. We'll work with you throughout and show you how your contributions changed the outcome."

Required at minimum:

- Complete the Engagement Assessment and Plan before anything goes public. Communications must review it before outreach launches.
- Publish an Influence Statement at the start and keep it visible at every touchpoint.
- Start pre-engagement conversations with trusted partners and community leaders before options are defined. If community members are first hearing about options at a meeting where they're already on the table, you started too late.
- Hold at least three sessions at different times, days, and locations.
- Book interpretation services the moment your Engagement Assessment and Plan is approved.
- At the midpoint, check who's in the room. If the communities most affected aren't represented, extend outreach before closing engagement.
- Produce a What We Heard summary after each major touchpoint, not just at the end.
- Show specifically how community input changed the direction of the work in the final recommendation. "Input was considered" isn't specific enough.

What it looks like:

A department is designing a housing stability program for low-income residents in a specific corridor. Staff spend six weeks in pre-engagement conversations with CBOs, neighborhood leaders, and service providers before anything goes public. Four listening sessions run across different locations and times, with food and childcare provided. A bilingual workshop lets participants respond to draft directions. Input changes eligibility criteria, the application format, and two proposed service locations.

Biggest mistake: Running Involve-level activities with a Consult-level mindset. If community input isn't visibly changing the direction of the work, you're collecting input, not involving people. Communities that have been through enough engagement processes to know the difference will stop showing up.

COLLABORATE

You're partnering with the community to develop solutions together. Participants have meaningful influence over the direction and outcome. Collaborate requires sustained commitment, significant resources, and a genuine willingness to let community input shape the final recommendation.

Your promise to the community:

"We'll build this together. Your recommendations will be incorporated to the maximum extent possible."

Required at minimum:

- Confirm executive and leadership support in writing before announcing anything publicly. Collaborate-level engagement without organizational backing fails.
- Contact the Clerk of the Board before forming any advisory committee, commission, or standing working group.
- Define decision-making authority before the first meeting and put it in writing. Share it with participants at the start.
- Compensate participants for their time. Build stipends, childcare reimbursement, and food into the budget from day one.
- Recruit intentionally from the communities most affected.
- Hold enough sessions for genuine relationship development before moving to recommendations. Trust doesn't develop in a single meeting.
- Document specifically how each community recommendation was incorporated into the final product, and why any weren't.

What it looks like:

A county department is developing a long-term service delivery plan for a specific geography. Staff spend ten weeks in pre-engagement conversations before forming a Community Advisory Group. CAG members are recruited from across the affected area with stipends and childcare provided at every session. The CAG meets monthly for five months, co-develops evaluation criteria for two proposed service models, and reviews the draft plan before it goes to the Board. The final Board report names each CAG recommendation, identifies which were incorporated, and explains the constraints that prevented two others.

Biggest mistake: forming an advisory body without resourcing it. A working group that isn't compensated, doesn't receive materials in advance, and has no clear line between its recommendations and county decisions isn't collaboration. It's the appearance of collaboration. Communities that have been through this recognize it immediately.

EMPOWER

The community makes the decision within a defined scope and budget. The county implements what the community decides. Used in limited circumstances and requires months of preparation before any decision-making begins.

Your promise to the community:
“We’ll implement what you decide.”

Required at minimum:

- Confirm executive support and a clearly defined scope and budget in writing before announcing anything publicly.
- Define the scope precisely before community education begins. Put it in every piece of public-facing material.
- Build a community education phase of at least four months before decision-making opens.
- Partner with CBOs and trusted community organizations from the start of the education phase, not when voting opens.
- Offer multiple ways to participate: in-person, online, and phone.
- Lower the participation age where the scope and subject matter allow.
- When the community decides, implement it. Then communicate publicly what was decided and when implementation is complete.

What it looks like:

A county health department sets aside \$150,000 for community wellness grants in an underserved geography. Leadership confirms scope in writing before any public announcement. Staff partner with local CBOs to reach residents who wouldn’t find the process through county channels. A community review panel recruited from the affected geography, compensated, and trained in their primary languages sets the criteria, reviews applications, and votes on awards. The county funds what the panel decides. Final awards and reasoning are published within 30 days.

Changing the scope or declining to implement the outcome after the process closes. If the community decides within the stated parameters and the county doesn’t follow through, the damage to trust is severe and not recoverable within that community’s memory. Don’t start unless the commitment to implement is real.

THE SEVEN REQUIRED STEPS

All seven. Every time. Internal alignment comes before external engagement.

■ Step 1: Determine Whether Engagement Is Required

Start with the Engagement Assessment and Plan. It tells you whether the effort requires engagement or communication, whether internal alignment is in place, whether you have the time and capacity to engage meaningfully, and what equity considerations apply.

REQUIRED	BEST PRACTICE
• Complete the Engagement Assessment and Plan before any outreach or engagement begins. • Communications must review the completed plan before outreach or engagement launches. • Retain the completed plan on file for the project. • For Board items: Attach the completed Engagement Assessment and Plan as an exhibit.	• Brief your supervisor before starting. Early alignment prevents mismatched expectations. • If the assessment reveals insufficient time or capacity, pause and redesign. • Before you begin, check with the relevant Board district office on budget, timeline, staffing, translation, legal review, and any other constraints.

■ Step 2: Define the Level of Public Influence

Use the Public Engagement Spectrum to determine the right level. Then draft and publish an Influence Statement before engagement begins.

REQUIRED	BEST PRACTICE
• Determine the appropriate engagement level using the spectrum before outreach begins. • Draft an Influence Statement and include it in all public-facing materials. • Document the level and statement in the Engagement Plan. • Include them in Board staff reports when applicable. • If the level changes mid-process, update the Influence Statement immediately and communicate the change to participants.	• If the level is unclear, consult Communications, Equity, or County Counsel before proceeding. • Test your Influence Statement with a trusted community partner before publishing. • When presenting to the Board, include the Influence Statement in the staff report so supervisors can see the commitment made to the community.

Step 3: Map the Community and Identify Stakeholders

Effective engagement starts with knowing who's affected. Before designing any outreach, map both the communities impacted by the decision and other relevant stakeholders who need to be aligned.

REQUIRED

- Use the Stakeholder Mapping Worksheet in the companion documents before designing the engagement plan.
- Identify specific groups, not broad categories. A road project doesn't affect "residents." It affects renters in a specific neighborhood, seniors without transportation, workers who commute through that corridor.
- Communications must review the completed stakeholder map before the plan is finalized.

BEST PRACTICE

- If the same 20 people keep showing up to every meeting, the map is incomplete. Change the outreach strategy and the engagement plan.
- Consult the Municipal Services Managers for West Marin and Marin City before any project touching those communities.
- Talk to staff in community-facing departments early.
- Brief the relevant Board district office and check in throughout the process.

Step 4: Design the Engagement Plan

Every county project that touches the public needs a Strategic Communications Plan. When engagement is required, the engagement plan becomes part of that document. The Strategic Communications Plan is included in the companion documents

REQUIRED

- Complete Part 1 of the Engagement Assessment and Plan before developing the Strategic Communications Plan.
- Communications must review and approve the completed plan before anything goes public.
- If anything changes mid-process, update both plans and notify Communications promptly.
- If the plan includes forming an advisory body, contact the Clerk of the Board before launch of public engagement.

BEST PRACTICE

- Design the plan with the least-accessible community in mind first. If it works for them, it'll work for everyone.
- Build in more time than seems necessary. Genuine engagement with hard-to-reach communities takes longer than standard outreach.
- Don't design alone. Use Communications and the Office of Equity as thought partners before the plan is finalized.

Step 5: Prepare for Meetings and Events

Well-designed engagement happens before you get in the room. Format, facilitation approach, and logistics determine who shows up, who feels welcome, and whether the input collected represents the communities most affected.

REQUIRED	BEST PRACTICE
• Complete the Public Meetings Worksheet in the companion documents before any public meeting or community event. • Secure language access and interpretation services in advance. See lead times in the Multilingual Engagement and Language Access section of this Plan. • Confirm the venue is ADA compliant and familiar to the community being engaged. • For virtual or hybrid meetings, contact the IST Broadcast team during the planning phase, not the week of the event. • Determine documentation roles and capture plan before the meeting begins. • At the close of every meeting, communicate what happens next, the decision timeline, and how participants will receive updates.	• Schedule meetings at times that account for work schedules, caregiving responsibilities, and community rhythms. Tuesday at 7 p.m. or Mondays at 9 a.m. are not neutral choices. • Consider an outside neutral facilitator for high-conflict or sensitive topics. • Open high-conflict meetings with community agreements. Having them before tension arises gives a neutral reference point when things get difficult. • Brief the facilitation team before every meeting: clarify roles, align on key messages, anticipate concerns, and agree on disruption protocols.

Step 6: Close the Loop and Report Back

Engagement isn't complete when the meeting ends. It's complete when the community understands what was heard, what changed as a result, and what didn't change and why. Skipping steps communicates that the community's time wasn't worth accounting for.

REQUIRED	BEST PRACTICE
• Every engagement effort at Consult level or higher requires a formal report-back. • Report-back materials must be distributed through the same channels used for outreach. • Preliminary summaries must be provided within 10 days of the close of active engagement. • Engagement summaries must be included in Board staff reports when applicable. • Final decisions must be communicated to participants with a clear explanation of how input was used and what constraints prevented further change. • If the timeline shifts or a decision is delayed, communicate proactively. Silence after engagement is one of the	• Maintain the Influence and Outcomes Tracker throughout the engagement process, not just at the end. Letting it lapse mid-process creates gaps that are hard to reconstruct. • When a community member raises a specific concern that needs a direct response, follow up through appropriate channels even if it doesn't appear in the public-facing report. People notice when their input disappears. • Anonymize all input in the What We Heard Report. Individual names are never included in public-facing materials without explicit written consent.

Step 7: Measure and Evaluate

Evaluation is how the county gets better at engagement over time. Every effort must be evaluated against the communities it was designed to reach, not just the number of people who showed up.

REQUIRED

- Use the Evaluation Template in the companion documents to document findings for every engagement effort.
- Share results internally with the engagement team, Communications, and the Office of Equity.

BEST PRACTICE

- A well-attended meeting that missed affected communities isn't a success. Evaluate who showed up relative to who was supposed to, not just headcount.
- Use evaluation findings to inform the next engagement effort. Build it into the project debrief.
- If evaluation reveals significant gaps, document and share with



QUICK REFERENCE

— DOCUMENTS BY LEVEL

Use this table after completing the Engagement Assessment and Plan to confirm your engagement level and required documents. Use this table after completing the Engagement Assessment and Plan to confirm your engagement level and required documents. OCE Communications must review the Plan before outreach begins at any level, and the completed Stakeholder Mapping Worksheet at Consult level and above.

LEVEL	REQUIRED DOCUMENTS
Inform	Engagement Assessment and Plan; Strategic Communications Plan
Consult	Engagement Assessment and Plan; Strategic Communications Plan; Stakeholder Mapping Worksheet; Influence and Outcomes Tracker; What We Heard Report
Involve	Engagement Assessment and Plan; Strategic Communications Plan; Stakeholder Mapping Worksheet; Meeting/Event Guide (if meetings are used); Influence and Outcomes Tracker; What We Heard Report; Evaluation
Collaborate	Engagement Assessment and Plan; Strategic Communications Plan; Stakeholder Mapping Worksheet; Meeting/Event Guide (if meetings are used); Influence and Outcomes Tracker; What We Heard Report; Evaluation; Clerk of the Board consultation (if forming an advisory body)
Empower	Engagement Assessment and Plan; Strategic Communications Plan; Stakeholder Mapping Worksheet; Meeting/Event Guide (if meetings are used); Influence and Outcomes Tracker; What We Heard Report; Evaluation; confirmed executive support; defined scope and decision authority in writing

■ Also include in every Board staff report:

- Engagement level used
- Communities engaged
- Summary of what was heard
- How input shaped the recommendation

Once the engagement level is confirmed, continue with the Stakeholder Mapping Worksheet and the engagement planning section of the Engagement Assessment and Plan.



When the Plan Isn't Followed...

Accountability for engagement rests with the department initiating the project. OCE Communications and/or Equity is the countywide partner, not the enforcer. Staff reports must explain absent engagement documentation. Repeated departures from Plan requirements may require remediation before a project advances.

PART TWO: GOING DEEPER



ENGAGING FOR EQUITY

Marin is home to some of the most civically active residents in California. The county also ranks as the third most racially disparate county in the state. Both things are true, and designing engagement that works requires understanding both.



- Marin's median household income is \$142,785, but the top 20% of earners make more than 22 times what the bottom 20% make.
- Between 2010 and 2023, lower-income households left the county at nearly double the rate of higher-income households, driven largely by housing costs.
- 64% of Marin's workforce commutes from outside the county, meaning many people affected by county decisions aren't available for standard weeknight meetings.
- 41.2% of local transit riders speak a language other than English at home. 31.2% speak English less than very well.
- The majority of Black and Latino households in Marin are low-income, reflecting persistent disparities in housing, economic mobility, and access to services.

Effective engagement isn't about holding more meetings, it's about designing processes that reflect the actual diversity of the county, reduce barriers to participation, and make it possible for the people most impacted by decisions to help shape them.

■ The Three Principles

Equity in engagement is practiced continuously. Three principles hold the work together.



INCLUSION

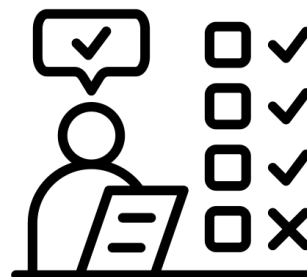
Inclusion means designing processes that make space for the people most affected by a decision, particularly those who've historically had the least access to government. It starts before the first meeting is scheduled. Casting the widest net isn't the goal. A process that reaches 500 people but misses the 50 most directly affected has failed its purpose.



LISTENING

Listening in public engagement is an active discipline. It means creating conditions where people feel safe enough to say what they actually think, not just what they think government wants to hear. Low turnout is data. Repeated concerns from the same community are data. Silence from a community that has every reason to care about a decision is data. Listen to what's said between the lines.

For guidance on responding to low turnout and other engagement challenges, contact OCE Communications or the Office of Equity.



CONSISTENCY

Trust is built through repeated, reliable behavior over time. Communities that've been let down by government processes in the past won't extend trust based on one good meeting. Consistency means showing up the same way every time: clear about influence, honest about constraints, and accountable to what was heard. Close the loop every time, not just when the outcome was positive.

DESIGN TO THE MARGINS FIRST. WHEN ENGAGEMENT WORKS FOR THE PEOPLE FACING THE MOST BARRIERS, IT TENDS TO WORK FOR EVERYONE.

WHY ENGAGEMENT

MATTERS IN MARIN

Marin County isn't one community. That sounds obvious, but it's easy to lose sight of in practice. West Marin contains communities with different histories, priorities, and relationships with County government. The Canal neighborhood and downtown San Rafael are a few miles apart and worlds different in terms of what residents need from an engagement process. Marin City carries a history with local government that shapes how residents show up, and whether they show up at all.

Effective engagement in Marin starts with knowing which community you're actually in, not just which zip code you're working in. Do the homework before outreach begins. Talk to staff who have relationships in the area. Connect with CBOs and community leaders who already have trust there. Understand what promises have been made, whether they were kept, and what residents may need to see before they believe this process will be different.

Project Relevance

Engagement only works if the project, program, or initiative genuinely matters to the communities being asked to participate. When a community's lived experiences, local knowledge, and history with government aren't woven into the engagement strategy, the process can feel predetermined. People sense when they've been invited to validate a decision rather than shape it.



BEST PRACTICE

- Community members' knowledge and lived experience have real value. Where budget allows, stipends signal that the county understands what it's asking of people.
- Sometimes the most effective engagement isn't led by the county at all. Knowing when to step back and support a trusted partner rather than lead is a skill,

The consequences are real, participation drops, and the same familiar faces keep showing up while others disengage entirely. Communities that felt unheard don't forget it, and that frustration surfaces later as organized opposition or pressure on elected officials. Closing the loop every time is one of the most direct ways to counter this. Reporting back on what was heard and what changed signals clearly that participation mattered. See Step 6 for guidance on the report-back process.

■ The Board of Supervisors and District Offices

Before external engagement begins on any project touching Board priorities or district constituents, brief the relevant supervisor's office. Supervisors and their aides hear things that don't make it through formal channels. Keeping them informed early ensures staff are aware of concerns, relationships, and community history that could shape the approach.

Briefing the district office isn't about getting political direction on technical work, but about making sure engagement efforts are grounded in what's happening in the community.

■ County Staff

Current staff are an often underrecognized engagement asset. Institutional knowledge, existing community relationships, and cultural understanding bring something no outreach strategy can fully replicate.

Some departments don't just serve the community; they are the community. MCFL, HHS, and Parks operate through direct, ongoing relationships with residents across every neighborhood and life circumstance. When a project touches the populations or geographies they serve, their staff already know things the engagement process is trying to learn.

The Clerk of the Board is a critical and often overlooked partner for any engagement effort involving a standing advisory body. If a project involves forming any advisory board, commission, or working group, the Clerk should be one of the first calls.

The Municipal Services Managers for West Marin and Marin City are irreplaceable. They know the history, the relationships, and the concerns that don't surface in formal settings. For any project touching either community, consult them before external outreach begins. Always and every time.

Representation matters. Communities engage more authentically when the people doing the engagement share their experiences and backgrounds. When that's not possible internally, trusted partners are the bridge.

■ Trusted Partners

Trusted partners are individuals, organizations, and institutions with established relationships, credibility, and trust within a community. They improve the reach, inclusiveness, and credibility of any engagement effort and are especially critical when working with communities that have experienced historical exclusion, language barriers, or distrust of government. People are far more likely to show up when the invitation comes from someone they already know.

Common trusted partners in Marin include CBOs, faith-based organizations, schools and parent groups, TAY programs, cultural and affinity organizations, nonprofits, advocacy groups, tenant associations, neighborhood leaders, senior centers, local businesses, health clinics, Community Resilience Teams, promotores, tribal representatives, and community ambassadors.

Sometimes the most effective engagement isn't led by the county at all. Knowing when to step back and support a trusted partner is part of doing this work well.

NOTE

What's captured here reflects what the County already knows so far. **Phase Two** will bring together an internal working group to examine current practices and surface gaps.

Phase Three takes this work into the community, neighborhood by neighborhood. This section will grow as that work unfolds.

MULTILINGUAL ENGAGEMENT AND LANGUAGE ACCESS

Nearly one in five Marin residents is Hispanic. A significant portion of the county's population speaks English less than very well.

■ Interpretation Lead Times

Plan around these minimums. Rush requests are possible at additional cost.

SERVICE	MIN. NOTICE
Over the Phone Interpretation	On demand, 24/7
Video Remote Interpretation	On demand or scheduled
On-Site Consecutive Interpretation	72 hours
On-Site Simultaneous Interpretation	2 weeks; 3 weeks if equipment needed
Virtual Simultaneous Interpretation	72 hours
ASL/CDI Interpretation	See Language Access Hub
Document Translation	Varies by length; submit early

For the full request process, vendor contacts, and request forms, visit the Language Access Hub.



Two distinctions that matter:

Translation is written

Documents, flyers, surveys, and materials converted from one language to another.

Interpretation is spoken

Live dialogue converted in real time. Different skills, different preparation, different logistics.

REQUIRED

- AI translation does not meet the county's language access obligations. Qualified human interpreters are required at engagement events.
- Language access costs and logistics must be built into the engagement plan before approval.

BEST PRACTICE

- Language varies within a language. Spanish in the Canal may differ from Spanish in West Marin's agricultural communities. Interpreters familiar with the specific community are almost always more effective.
- Build a few minutes into the start of every multilingual meeting for a language access announcement. It signals that participants' language needs were anticipated, not addressed as an afterthought.

DIGITAL ENGAGEMENT

AND AI

Technology extends the reach of engagement when used with intention. Without knowing the rules going in, it can also create liability, public records exposure, and language access failures.

Public Records Obligations

Everything AI generates in connection with county work is a public record. Transcripts, meeting summaries, survey analyses, and the prompts sent to AI tools are all subject to PRA disclosure. AI-generated transcripts must be retained per the county's records retention schedule and can't be deleted after a meeting.

Before Turning It On

REQUIRED

- California requires all-party consent before any recording or transcription starts. Include notice in the meeting invitation and state it verbally at the start of every session.
- If anyone objects to AI transcription, use a human notetaker.
- If an external participant joins with their own AI tool running, ask them to turn it off. If they won't, note it for the record and consult County Counsel.
- Use county-approved tools only. Don't feed community input into unvetted third-party systems.
- Never use AI transcription in closed sessions or meetings involving personnel matters or legal counsel.

Accuracy and human review

Accents, non-English speakers, and community-specific language are where these tools fail most frequently. Those are frequently the voices that matter most in engagement work.

REQUIRED

- Every AI-generated transcript must be reviewed and corrected by the engagement lead within five business days, before it's used in any What We Heard summary, staff report, or public-facing document.
- The staff member signing off is accountable for accuracy. Not the tool.

Virtual and hybrid meetings

For county-hosted virtual or hybrid meetings, the IST Broadcast team provides technical support. Contact them during the planning phase, not the week of the event.

BEST PRACTICE

- Digital participation data needs careful interpretation. An online survey reaching 500 people means little if it missed the communities most affected. Numbers aren't the same as representation.
- Every digital engagement strategy needs an accessible alternative for people without reliable internet, devices, or digital comfort.

REACHING

UNDERREPRESENTED

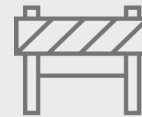
COMMUNITIES

Populations consistently underrepresented in Marin engagement

- Youth and young adults
- Seniors and older adults
- Communities of color and historically marginalized groups
- Limited English proficient individuals
- People with disabilities
- Low-income and economically burdened residents
- Undocumented and mixed-status households
- Agricultural and service industry workers
- Long-term homeowners on fixed incomes
- People with limited digital access or low literacy
- People experiencing housing instability or homelessness

BEST PRACTICE

- Trusted partners, promotores, and community-based organizations already embedded in communities are among the most valuable engagement assets available. Partner early and compensate fairly.
- Where budget allows, stipends, childcare, food, and transportation support aren't extras. They're what makes participation possible for the people who matter most.



The communities most often described as hard to reach aren't disengaged. They face barriers that standard outreach wasn't designed to address. Naming those barriers honestly is the first step to removing them.

■ Barriers and what works

BARRIER	WHAT HELPS
Language access	Qualified interpreters, translated materials, bilingual staff or partners
Caregiving obligations	Onsite childcare, stipends, virtual participation options
Transportation	Pop-up events closer to community, stipends
Work schedules	Evening and weekend meetings, recorded sessions, multiple touchpoints
Trust and historical harm	Lead with trusted partners, build relationships before the project begins
Cultural and social barriers	Food, storytelling, partnerships with faith-based and cultural organizations
Fear and safety concerns	Anonymous participation, minimize personal data collection, use trusted intermediaries
Disability access	ADA-accessible venues, ASL, captioning, large print, advance materials
Digital access and literacy	Paper surveys, phone options, community locations with internet access
Youth engagement	Social media, peer networks, school partnerships, contests, stipends

APPENDICES



ENGAGEMENT TOOLBOX

A reference guide to engagement methods matched to the Public Engagement Spectrum. Not a checklist. Select methods that match the engagement level determined in Step 2, the communities you're trying to reach, and the resources available.

Equity Principles for All Tools

PRINCIPLE	WHAT IT MEANS IN PRACTICE
Compensate participation	Stipends, childcare reimbursement, and food lower barriers and signal respect. Build compensation into the engagement plan.
Never rely on one channel	No single tool reaches all communities. Combine in-person and digital, English and non-English, formal and informal settings.
Meet people where they are	Go to the places, times, and formats that work for the community, not the other way around.
Use trusted partners	CBOs, promotores, and neighborhood leaders can reach communities the county cannot. Compensate them fairly.
Close the loop, always	Every tool that collects input creates an obligation to report back through the same channels used for outreach.



Low = minimal staff time and budget.

Med = planned staff time, some budget.

High = dedicated staff capacity, significant budget and coordination.

Inform

TOOL	BEST USED WHEN	ACCESSIBILITY NOTES	RESOURCES
Press Release / Media Advisory	Announcing decisions or meetings; high-interest topics	Translate for Spanish-language outlets; distribute to community radio	Low
Project Landing Page	Any project requiring ongoing communication	WCAG 2.1 compliance required; translate key content; include non-digital contact option	Low-Med
Email Newsletter	Maintaining contact with previously engaged community members	Offer plain-text version; translate for multilingual lists	Low
Social Media	Reaching broader or younger audiences; time-sensitive updates	Alt text on all images; plain language; vary platforms by audience	Low
Fact Sheet / FAQ	Introducing a new project; addressing common questions	Translate; 6th grade reading level or below; offer large print	Low
Public / Legal Notice	Brown Act or CEQA requirements; Board actions	Check language access requirements; post at community locations	Low
Direct Mailer / Door Hanger	Reaching residents without internet; localized geographic impact	Translate for high-LEP neighborhoods; include QR code and phone number	Med
Informational Signage	Construction or capital projects	Bilingual text where applicable; QR code and phone number	Low

Consult

TOOL	BEST USED WHEN	ACCESSIBILITY NOTES	RESOURCES
Online Survey	Gathering broad input on options	Always offer a paper or phone alternative; translate; keep under 10 minutes	Low-Med
Paper / Comment Card	Reaching residents without digital access; tabling events	Translate; plain language; provide pens and secure collection box	Low
Open House	Projects with spatial or visual components	ADA-accessible community locations; multilingual staff; varied times	Med
Listening Session	Early in a process before options are defined	Accessible locations; interpretation; anonymous comment option	Med
Office Hours / Drop-In	Individuals uncomfortable in group settings	Offer virtual option; publicize through trusted partner networks	Low
Phone Hotline / Comment Line	Reaching residents without internet	Bilingual or interpretation staffing; document all input received	Med
Virtual Q&A / Webinar	Reaching residents who can't attend in person	Live captioning; language interpretation; record and post; contact IST Broadcast early	Med

Involve

TOOL	BEST USED WHEN	ACCESSIBILITY NOTES	RESOURCES
Workshop	Developing or refining alternatives	Childcare and stipends where possible; multiple sessions at varied times and locations	Med-High
Design Charrette	Complex land use or infrastructure projects	Multiple entry points; interpret throughout; recruit from all affected neighborhoods	High
Focus Group	Deep qualitative insight from a specific population	Compensate participants; community-trusted locations; culturally fluent facilitators	Med
Pop-Up / Tabling	Reaching people where they already are	Attend events hosted by and for the communities you're trying to reach; bilingual staff	Med
Door-to-Door Outreach	High-impact projects in specific geographic areas	Partner with CBOs or promotores; conduct in community's primary languages	High
Multilingual Community Meeting	Projects affecting LEP populations	Simultaneous or consecutive interpretation; translate materials in advance	Med-High

Collaborate

TOOL	BEST USED WHEN	ACCESSIBILITY NOTES	RESOURCES
Community Advisory Committee	Long-term projects requiring sustained input	Contact the Clerk of the Board before forming. Compensate participants. Recruit from most-affected communities.	High
Stakeholder Working Group	Policy or program development with clear deliverables	Balance technical experts with community members with lived experience; define decision-making authority upfront	High
Co-Design Session	Program or service design where community experience should shape the product	Center most-affected communities; provide stipends; build relationship time before co-design begins	High
Community Ambassador / Promotor Program	Reaching communities that don't engage with county government directly	Compensate ambassadors fairly; provide training and ongoing support	Med-High

Involve

TOOL	BEST USED WHEN	ACCESSIBILITY NOTES	RESOURCES
Participatory Budgeting	Defined budget and scope available for community decision-making; executive support confirmed	Lower the voting age when appropriate; multiple voting options; partner with CBOs	High
Community-Led Grant Allocation	Grant programs intended to serve specific communities; equity is an explicit goal	Capacity-building for smaller applicants; technical assistance in primary languages	High

SAMPLE ENGAGEMENT

TIMELINES

There is no standard engagement timeline because history, language access needs, staff capacity, Board calendar, and trust all shape it in ways no template can anticipate. What the table below gives you is a floor, not a ceiling.

LEVEL	MIN. PLANNING LEAD	ACTIVE ENGAGEMENT	REPORT-BACK	MINIMUM TOTAL
Inform	2 weeks	N/A	1 week	3 weeks
Consult	4 to 6 weeks	2 to 3 weeks	2 weeks	8 to 11 weeks
Involve	6 to 8 weeks	4 to 6 weeks	3 weeks	13 to 17 weeks
Collaborate	10 to 14 weeks	6 to 10 weeks	4 weeks	20 to 28 weeks
Empower	4 to 6 months	Ongoing	Ongoing	6+ months

These are minimum lead times under favorable conditions. Complex projects, hard-to-reach communities, multilingual engagement, and low baseline trust all require more time. Plan accordingly.

What It Looks Like in Practice

A county planning department is redesigning a community park in a neighborhood with a significant Spanish-speaking population and a history of low participation in county processes. Staff spend four weeks in pre-engagement conversations with local CBOs and neighborhood leaders before anything goes public. Three bilingual listening sessions run at different times and locations, with food and childcare provided. A bilingual survey runs concurrently. Input shapes the final design priorities before the project goes to the

Board. A bilingual What We Heard summary goes back to participants through the same channels used for outreach within 30 days.

HIRING

A CONSULTANT

Engagement is complex work and needing outside support isn't a failure of capacity. It's a realistic response to what the work takes.

Before looking anywhere else, contact the OCE Communications Division or the Office of Equity. Both teams maintain relationships with trusted consultants with experience in Bay Area government engagement. Starting there saves time, prevents mismatches, and ensures consistency with how the county approaches this work.

■ The Real Cost

Consultants bring process design skills, facilitation capacity, and the ability to run engagement activities that staff can't always sustain alongside regular workloads. But there's a real trade-off.

Consultants who aren't already embedded in Marin's communities must build trust from scratch. A consultant effective in general but unfamiliar with West Marin or government in general, will need significant onboarding before they're ready to engage that community. Build that time into the budget and timeline from day one.

■ What Staff Still Owns

Hiring a consultant doesn't transfer ownership. Staff remain responsible for internal alignment before engagement begins, for the Influence Statement, for keeping leadership informed throughout, and for closing the loop after the process ends. The consultant facilitates. The county is still accountable to the community.



What to Look For

Community experience over general credentials. Ask specifically about their work with communities like ours. A track record with Bay Area local government is a meaningful differentiator.

Process design versus public relations. Know which one you need. For most county projects, it's the former.

Impartiality. If the community perceives the consultant as the county's advocate, the engagement will produce diminished results regardless of how well the process is designed.

Willingness to build capacity. The best consultants transfer knowledge while they work, not dependency. Look for someone who treats county staff as partners.

GLOSSARY

Terms used throughout this Plan are defined here in plain language. Where a term has a specific meaning within the County of Marin’s framework, that meaning is noted.

Accessibility: The design of materials, meeting formats, and environments so that all community members can use and participate in them. In practice, this means considering language, disability, transportation, digital access, and other barriers before launching any engagement effort.

Accountability: The expectation that the County will be open and honest about how decisions are made, how public input was used, and what happened because of community engagement.

Active Listening: A form of listening designed to make the speaker feel genuinely heard. It involves non-verbal cues that signal attention, open-ended questions to draw out information, and paraphrasing to confirm understanding. Active listening is a core skill for county staff facilitating public engagement.

Advocacy: Actions taken to support the interests of specific communities or causes. Community advocates often participate in public engagement processes, and their involvement should be welcomed and documented.

Audience: The population or group of people that staff are seeking to inform or engage. Also called the “intended audience.” Identifying the right audience is

a required step before designing any engagement effort.

Barrier: Any obstacle that prevents or discourages participation. Barriers can be physical, linguistic, cultural, economic, technological, or systemic. Staff must identify and actively work to reduce barriers as part of engagement planning.

Brown Act: California’s open meeting law (the Ralph M. Brown Act) that requires local government bodies to conduct their business in public. Brown Act meetings are not automatically engagement. They’re a legal requirement for formal action, not a substitute for meaningful community dialogue.

Brown Act Meeting: A formal, legally required public meeting at which a quorum of a decision-making body conducts official business. These meetings follow strict procedures and limit interactive dialogue. In many cases, more effective engagement should happen before a Brown Act meeting occurs.

Capacity Building: The process of improving a community’s or organization’s ability to engage effectively. For county staff, this means building skills in facilitation, cultural responsiveness, conflict management, and equity-centered design.

Closing the Loop: The required practice of reporting back to community members after an engagement process to explain what was heard, how input influenced the decision, and what happens next. Engagement is incomplete without it.

Co-design: A collaborative process in which community members and government staff jointly develop solutions, plans, or policies. Co-design gives community members meaningful influence over outcomes.

Collaboration: A level of engagement on the Public Engagement Spectrum in which the County partners with stakeholders to develop alternatives and identify preferred solutions. Public influence is high.

Common Ground: Shared opinions, interests, or values that exist among people who may disagree on other things. Identifying common ground is a facilitation technique that can move difficult conversations forward.

Communication (Outreach): The one-way sharing of information with the public about decisions, programs, or updates. Communication informs; it does not invite influence. If an outcome

cannot be changed based on feedback, the effort must be labeled communication, not engagement.

Community: A group of people connected by shared geography, culture, identity, experience, or interest. “The community” is not a monolith. Staff must identify which specific communities are affected by a given decision.

Community Agreements: A brief set of shared expectations established at the start of a public meeting or engagement event to create an environment of respectful dialogue. Example: “We will listen before responding.”

Community-Based Organization (CBO): A nonprofit or grassroots organization that serves or advocates for a specific community or population. CBOs are often trusted messengers and valuable partners in reaching communities that are hard to reach through standard outreach.

Community Mapping: The process of identifying and documenting who is affected by a decision before designing engagement. Includes primary and secondary stakeholders, equity considerations, and participation barriers. Required in Step 3 of the Seven Required Steps.

Conflict Management: The ability to recognize and manage tension or disagreement during public engagement processes so that all parties can continue to participate productively. Conflict is not failure. It often means the issue matters deeply to people.

Consensus: An outcome from group decision-making in which

participants reach an agreement that all are willing to support, even if it's not everyone's first choice.

Consult: A level of engagement on the Public Engagement Spectrum in which the County seeks feedback on options or draft proposals before a final decision is made. Input can shape aspects of the outcome.

Cultural Responsiveness: The practice of adapting engagement methods, materials, and formats to reflect the cultural values, languages, communication styles, and historical contexts of specific communities.

Decision-Maker: Any county staff member, appointed official, or elected body that holds authority to make a final determination on a project, policy, or program. Staff must clearly communicate who the decision-maker is at the start of every engagement effort.

Design to the Margins: An equity approach to engagement planning that prioritizes those most affected and most likely to face barriers to participation. When engagement works for the most marginalized, it tends to work for everyone.

Dialogue: A structured conversation intended to build mutual understanding between parties. Unlike debate, dialogue doesn't seek to win. It seeks to deepen relationships and surface perspectives that improve decision-making.

Disproportionate Impact: When a decision, policy, or project affects certain communities more heavily than others, particularly communities that have historically been underrepresented or underserved. Identifying

disproportionate impact is a required part of engagement planning.

Disparities: Measurable differences in outcomes between specific groups or populations. Disparities in Marin, including those related to race, income, and geography, must be considered when designing engagement strategies.

Diversity: The presence of differences within a population, including race, ethnicity, gender, age, language, ability, income, sexual orientation, and lived experience. Diversity in the room doesn't automatically mean equity in the process.

Empower: The highest level of engagement on the Public Engagement Spectrum, used in limited circumstances where final decision-making authority is placed directly in the hands of the public. Examples include participatory budgeting and voter-approved measures.

Engagement Group: Participants in an engagement effort whose characteristics can be compared to the broader affected population to assess whether the right communities were reached.

Engagement Assessment Plan
A required document that staff must complete before launching any engagement effort. It ensures that engagement is necessary, appropriately scoped, equity-centered, and aligned with the level of influence available. See Step 1 of the Seven Required Steps.

Engagement Plan: A structured document, required for all engagement efforts beyond informational outreach, that outlines the decision being

made, the level of influence, the stakeholder strategy, engagement methods, timeline, roles, resources, and evaluation criteria. See Step 4 of the Engagement Decision Framework.

Equity: Recognizing that different communities have different circumstances and that resources and opportunities must be intentionally allocated to support equal outcomes. Equity is not the same as equality. It requires identifying who's most affected and designing processes that give them meaningful access.

Ethnicity: An individual's shared cultural or national background. A distinct concept from race.

Facilitation: A structured process used to help groups have constructive dialogue on complex or contentious issues. A skilled facilitator creates conditions where all participants feel respected and able to contribute.

Hard-to-Reach Communities: Communities that are less likely to engage through traditional outreach channels due to historical mistrust of government, language barriers, work schedules, immigration status, or other systemic factors. "Hard to reach" often reflects barriers the county hasn't yet removed, not lack of interest.

IAP2: The International Association for Public Participation. A global professional organization that develops standards and frameworks for public participation, including the widely used Spectrum of Public Participation that informs the County of Marin's Public Engagement Spectrum.

Inclusion: More than diversity in numbers, inclusion means that

all participants, particularly those historically excluded, experience authentic and meaningful opportunities to participate and influence outcomes.

Influence Statement: A required statement, included in all public-facing engagement materials, that clearly communicates what is open to community input, what is not, who makes the final decision, and when the decision will be made. See Step 2 of the Seven Required Steps.

Inform: The baseline level of engagement on the Public Engagement Spectrum. The goal is to provide the public with clear, accurate information. Public influence is none. If an outcome cannot be changed, the effort must be labeled informational, not engagement.

Input: The feedback, opinions, and perspectives collected from community members through an engagement process. Input must be documented, considered, and reported back on.

Intersectionality: The recognition that people hold multiple overlapping identities (race, gender, income, immigration status, disability, etc.) that interact and shape their experiences, including their experiences with government.

Involve: A level of engagement on the Public Engagement Spectrum in which the County works directly with affected communities throughout the process. Community concerns and ideas actively shape the direction of the work.

Language Access: The provision of translation and interpretation services so that community members whose primary language is

not English can meaningfully participate in engagement processes. Language access is a legal obligation and an equity imperative, not an optional add-on.

Listening Session: A structured engagement format designed to hear from community members about their concerns, priorities, and experiences before decisions are made. Listening sessions are two-way and dialogue-based, not informational.

Marginalization: The systematic exclusion of certain people or communities from resources, decision-making, and opportunities to participate.

Noticing: The process of formally informing the public about engagement opportunities, project updates, or public meetings. Legal notice requirements may apply under the Brown Act or other state and local laws.

Participatory Budgeting: A democratic process in which community members directly decide how to allocate a portion of a public budget. An example of the Empower level of engagement.

Plain Language: Communication that is clear, direct, and free of jargon so that community members can understand it the first time they read or hear it. Plain language is a requirement for all public-facing engagement materials.

Engagement Assessment and Plan: A required document that staff must complete before launching any engagement effort. It ensures that engagement is necessary, appropriately scoped, equity-centered, and aligned with the level of influence available.

See Step 1 of the Engagement Decision Framework.

Public: Anyone with a stake in county decisions, including residents, workers, renters, visitors, service recipients, and business owners. In an engagement context, a person becomes a member of the public the moment they're in a setting that is open, announced, or convened to collect input that informs a decision.

Public Engagement: A structured, intentional process in which community members have a meaningful opportunity to influence a decision, shape an outcome, or inform the direction of a county project, program, or policy. Engagement is two-way. It requires follow-through and reporting back.

Public Engagement Spectrum: The County of Marin's framework for defining and communicating the level of public influence in any given engagement effort. The five levels are: Inform, Consult, Involve, Collaborate, and Empower.

Public Outreach: One-way efforts to inform the public about County projects, decisions, or updates. Also called communication. Outreach is not engagement unless community input can meaningfully influence the outcome.

Public Participation: The broader process through which people receive information from and provide input to decision-makers. Public participation includes both outreach and engagement.

Race: The social grouping of people, often based on physical characteristics, national origin, or sociocultural background. Race is

a social construct, not a biological one.

Report-Back (What We Heard): A required summary produced after engagement efforts at the Consult level or higher. It documents what was heard, how input influenced the decision, what couldn't change and why, and what happens next.

Representation: The inclusion of diverse voices and perspectives in public processes so that decisions reflect the actual range of people affected, not just those easiest to reach.

"Same Twenty People"

Syndrome: The tendency for public engagement processes to consistently attract the same vocal, organized, or well-resourced participants while missing those most affected by a decision. Equity-centered engagement actively works to break this pattern.

Situation Assessment: The process of gathering information to determine what kind of engagement is needed, who the key stakeholders are, what level of influence is available, and what risks exist. Completed as part of Step 1 of the Engagement Decision Framework.

Social Inclusion: The process of improving conditions so that individuals and groups can fully take part in civic life, including public decision-making processes.

Sponsor Agency: The department or team responsible for designing and conducting engagement on a specific project, policy, or program.

Stakeholder: Any community member, organization, or institution that is affected by or

has a stake in a county decision. Stakeholders include those who support, oppose, or are indifferent to a proposal.

Stakeholder Mapping: The documented process of identifying who is affected by a decision, who may be excluded without intentional outreach, and what barriers to participation exist. Required in Step 3 of the Engagement Decision Framework.

Structural Exclusion: Systems, policies, and practices, often historical in origin, that have intentionally or functionally excluded certain communities from civic participation. Acknowledging structural exclusion is foundational to equity-centered engagement.

Transparency: Providing community members with honest, accessible information about what the County is doing, why, what's open for input, and how decisions will be made.

Trust: The foundation of effective community engagement. Trust is built through consistent follow-through, honest communication, and genuine responsiveness to community input. It can take years to build and can be lost quickly.

Underrepresentation: The condition in which certain groups are not proportionately included in engagement processes relative to their presence in the affected population.

Vulnerable Populations: Communities that face heightened risk of harm from decisions, often due to economic disadvantage, racial inequity, lack of access to services, disability, or other systemic factors. Engagement planning must account for and prioritize their inclusion.

IMPLEMENTATION AND ROLLOUT

Adopting the Plan is the first step. Full implementation across all county departments will take time, intentional training, and sustained accountability. Realistically, that’s an 18 to 24 month journey from Board adoption.

■ What Full Implementation Means

Every staff member who initiates or manages public-facing projects uses the Engagement Assessment and Plan, publishes an Influence Statement, and closes the loop after every engagement effort. The seven required steps become a habit, not a checklist pulled out for audits.

■ Note on High-Conflict and Controversial Issues

Dedicated guidance on high-conflict engagement design will be developed during Phase Two of this Plan’s rollout. It will address when to bring in external facilitation, how to sequence engagement to reduce polarization, and how to maintain credibility when decisions are unpopular.

■ Setting Realistic Expectations

Not every department will implement at the same pace. Departments with large public-facing portfolios, including HHS, Public Works, CDA, and Parks, will likely move faster because the need is immediate.

The metric for success at 18 months isn’t perfection. It’s a meaningful shift: more Engagement Assessment and Plans filed, more Influence Statements published, more What We Heard reports closed. The habit is the goal.

OCE Communications will report on implementation progress annually to the County Executive, with a summary available to the Board upon request.

Full Implementation Plan
Phase 1: Launch (June 2026)
Board adoption of the Plan. OCE Communications distributes it countywide and all new public-facing engagement efforts begin using the Engagement Assessment and Plan immediately.
Phase 2: Internal Learning (July – September, 2026)
Departments examine current practices together, surface what’s working, and strengthen this document based on real experience.
Phase 3: Community-Informed (October 2026 – February 2027)
Direct community input shapes future editions of the Plan.



CITATIONS AND RESOURCES

Data Citations

- U.S. Census Bureau, American Community Survey, 2019-2023 5-Year Estimates, Table B19081, Marin County, California.
- Rooted in Marin, “Why This Matters.” Also see: U.S. Census Bureau, 2023 American Community Survey 1-Year Estimates.
- Longitudinal Employer-Household Dynamics, U.S. Census Bureau, Center for Economic Studies, 2022.
- Marin Transit, 2023 Title VI Program Update, Adopted June 2023.
- U.S. Census Bureau, 2022 American Community Survey 5-Year Estimates.

Additional Resources

- IAP2 Spectrum of Public Participation: iap2.org
- Institute for Local Government (ILG) Sample Public Engagement RFPs/RFQs: ca-ilg.org
- Language Access Hub:
LanguageAccess@MarinCounty.gov
- IST Broadcast Team (virtual meeting support):
contact via county intranet
- OCE Communications Division: engagement plan review, consultant referrals, training
- Office of Equity: equity-centered engagement design support
- Clerk of the Board: any engagement involving advisory bodies, commissions, or working groups

EDITOR'S NOTE

Public engagement gives communities a genuine opportunity to shape decisions before they're made. Strategic communication shares what's already been decided. Both are essential to how the county shows up for the people it serves, and doing each one well starts with being honest about which one you're doing.

Relationships are what make the difference between engagement that works and engagement that doesn't, and the counties and communities that get this right aren't the ones with the best tools or the most meetings. They're the ones that show up consistently, tell the truth about what's open to input and what isn't, and recognize that the people closest to a problem usually understand it better than we do.

Early engagement surfaces what staff can't see from the inside. Concerns get identified before they harden, unintended consequences get caught before they get expensive, and communities that feel heard come back. The cost of skipping it is just as predictable: projects stall, budgets get consumed by redesigns, and communities that never heard back stop showing up.

Every tool and template in this Plan exists to support that work, but it isn't comprehensive. Real engagement is too context-dependent for any document to fully capture. What's here is a starting point built on years of practice, honest feedback, and hard lessons. Treat it that way.

Phase Two brings county staff together to examine what we're doing across departments and surface what's missing. Phase Three takes the work directly into the community. We want you to use what's here, push back when something doesn't fit, share what you learn about community, and close the loop.

We're grateful to everyone who contributed to the development of this Plan: the staff who've been doing this work quietly and well for years, the community partners who've trusted us enough to keep showing up, and the colleagues who pushed for something better than what we had before. That includes:

Yours in community,

Laine Hendricks
Director of Countywide Communication

